

Analytical Memo

As you analyze your data, write an analytical memo. Think of this as a memo to yourself or your colleagues (if you were on a research team).

Rogers (2012) Described, “When you reflect and write about data analysis and your thinking with the coding process, it increases your critical thinking and challenges your own assumptions. It is not necessary to write analytic memos in formal, academic jargon; memos should read like personal letters to a friend”¹ (p. 890).

Researchers can write about **anything** they want in the memo. Here are some suggestions:

- Describe your data, what you are analyzing.
- Describe your process in detail, how you analyzed the data.
- Explain decisions you made about the data and its analysis.
- Explain how the data is in conversation.
- Describe what you discovered about your topic.
- Describe how what you learned can help you answer your research question.

Researchers can also think about their own relation to the data. For example:

- How might my background or beliefs may be shaping my interpretation of the data?
- Are there alternate interpretations to the one I am seeing?
- Am I being transparent and objective in my analysis?

After completing the analysis of the data for my AP Research project on independent artists and social media algorithms, I have to say that the process of coding the data was of great interest to me. I analyzed nine different public texts between the years 2020 and 2025, including six articles written by visual artists and three official ranking guides from Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube. Furthermore, I used two different passes to highlight and categorize the sentences from each of these texts into major themes or findings. For instance, the initial codes of “reach collapse” and “audience instability” were categorized into the major finding that an artist’s audience can become unstable, even if they have a significant amount of followers established for their art. I chose to exclude the paywalled content and private comments from these articles to ensure that

¹ Rogers, R. H. (2018). Coding and writing analytic memos on qualitative data: A review of Johnny Saldaña’s *The Coding Manual for Qualitative Researchers*. *The Qualitative Report*, 23(4), 889–892. Retrieved from <https://nsuworks.nova.edu/tqr/vol23/iss4/12>

the research was ethical and could be replicated. Consequently, by omitting this content, I may have excluded other interpretations from the artists of these social media platforms. Since I personally use social media platforms as much as the independent artists that wrote these articles, I entered the project with some sympathy for the creators. However, I had to ensure that I remained objective in my interpretation of the content published by the social media companies. One of the more interesting findings from the article was the difference in the vocabularies that the platforms and the independent artists use to describe the same recommendation systems for the platforms' content. For example, the social media companies like to use positive words to describe the use of algorithms to recommend content to viewers, but the independent artists use words related to survival within these platforms. I was aware that the algorithms for these social media platforms would reduce the number of views that an independent artist receives, but I was not aware of the impact that this algorithm can have on the artists to force them to change their art and content to continue gaining views for their art. Consequently, I can understand why independent artists encourage their fans to create websites and email lists for themselves to protect their authentic work. Overall, through this research project, I have discovered the way in which navigating the social media platforms can have an impact upon the digital artists of today.